

The Hollow Crown of Vehl

a series in ten books

BOOK I

The Eighth Ash

— Chapter Six —

CHAPTER VI

A Knock at the Wrong Hour

He had not, in the catacombs, expected to sleep.

He had not, in the corridor under Sera's house, expected to sleep. He had not, on the warm wood of Sera's front hall, expected to sleep. He had expected, in fact, to spend the night in the small relentless inventory that had been his mind's occupation since the moment he had opened his eyes in the salt-circle: the inventory of debts, the inventory of wards, the inventory of allies, the inventory of seconds between him and the men who were coming. He had expected to take the night the way he had taken the last night of his old life, which he had spent at his desk with the building manager's name on a draft email and the spreadsheet of bracket-load tolerances open in the second window of his work laptop — late, awake, working a problem.

He had been asleep for, he understood when he opened his small wrong eye, three and a half hours.

The understanding was the Ledger's. The Ledger ticked the duration up beside his attention without comment, the way a clock in a hotel room ticks the hour up at a wakeful guest. He read it. He let it settle. He thought, with a small slow shock that he set down behind the slower understandings: I slept. I slept on the floor of a stranger's hall, in a body I have known for eight hours, in a city I have not yet seen by light, and I did not wake to check whether I was being followed.

He thought: that is a thing that has not happened to me since I was a small boy in Sapporo.

He thought: I do not yet know whether it is a good thing.

He sat up.

The hall was dim. Someone had drawn a thick curtain across the small window over the door; the cool blue light of the lanterns of the Quarter was filtered through

the curtain in a pale narrow line on the floor. He could hear, somewhere deeper in the house, the small even breathing of a person asleep. He could hear, somewhere deeper than that, the slow tick of a clock that had a different cadence than the clocks of his old world — six beats and then a held breath and then six more beats. He could hear, from the room to his left, the heavier wet breathing of Aren Mosk, who had been put to bed in the back room and who was, by the sound of him, deep enough into sleep that he had begun to dream.

Kael did not, immediately, move.

He took stock the way he had been teaching himself to take stock. *Inventory.*

The wards on his ribs: five of seven, all five active, the second now at 1.00 integrity, the others holding. *Debts:* five entries on the Ledger, listed in the order he had earned them — the body of Mireille Vasc, the death of the lead sigilist, the warning written in the unknown

hand, the slow collapse of the Reliquary of the Third Order, and now — added at some point during his three and a half hours of sleep — a sixth.

He looked at the sixth.

NEW DEBT (held by you):

one hour of unobserved rest,
given by SERA ILYNE VASQUAIRE,
on a floor she has not had anyone
on for two years.

weight: small, but specific.
the Ledger notes that this is the
first debt entered against you that
was incurred while you were not
awake to incur it.

the donor was awake. she did not
ask whether you wanted it.

He read that line three times.

He understood it, by the third reading, in two registers at once. On the surface, it was a small accounting note: Sera had let him sleep, and in letting him sleep she had stood watch over him for some portion of the night, and

her watching was an act she had performed at a cost to herself, and the Ledger had recorded the cost.

Underneath, in the quieter register, the Ledger was telling him a thing about Sera he had not yet asked: that she had decided, at some point in the small hours, that the imp on her front hall floor was a thing that could be left to sleep. She had decided this not because he had earned it. He had not, by any honest accounting, earned it in the eight hours she had known him. She had decided it because she had wanted to. She had decided it as an act of small unrequired generosity, and the Ledger, which had nothing else to call that act, had filed it as a debt.

He sat with the registration. He did not, this time, set it down. He left it in his attention for a small slow span of seconds and let himself look at it directly.

He thought, with the cold small honesty he had cultivated all his old life: I have not, in nine years of professional work and six years of professional chess and a childhood in the silent house of two unhappy

adults, been watched in my sleep by a person who wished me well.

He thought: this is, mathematically, the first time.

He thought: I do not know what to do with it.

He filed the line as still-being-processed.

He stood up.

His small thin legs were stiffer than they had been at the top of the Lift. He was, he understood by the second step, mildly hungry — not the Ledger-Hunger, which was the capacity to hold debt, but the older hunger of any body that has not been fed in its first day of life. He had been born, in some technical sense, perhaps fourteen hours ago. He had not eaten. He had bitten Aren Mosk in the reliquary, but the act there had been transactional; the Ledger had taken the cost and the body had been a witness to the transaction more than a beneficiary of it. The Imp of the Eighth Ash, he understood, would need to eat soon.

He thought: I will mention this to Sera.

He thought: but not yet.

He padded, on the soundless small feet of the small new body, the length of the hall.

The hall opened into a kitchen. He had not been able, last night, to see the kitchen; Sera had taken him directly from the front hall down a corridor to a small low room with a folded blanket on the floor and had said, in a voice still hoarse, "*sleep if you wish, or sit if you do not. The door behind you locks.*" He had been planning to sit. He had, in the act of folding his small body into a corner of the blanket to think about what to do next, sat down once and then quite suddenly not been awake. He understood, in retrospect, that the sleeping had been the body's decision and not his own. The body had decided that the room was safe enough to lower its watch. The body had been right.

The kitchen was small and clean and lit by the slow paling of an early dawn through a single small window

high in the eastern wall. There was a low iron stove against the inner wall. There was a square wooden table in the center of the room, with two chairs, both worn smooth at the seats. There was a shelf along the back wall on which sat several glass jars in a careful row. There was, on the table, a wooden bowl.

Inside the bowl, three slices of cold pale meat had been laid out in a small fan. Beside the bowl, a small clay cup had been set, with water in it. Beside the cup, a folded square of parchment with the corner of it held down by the cup, so that it would not blow away if a wind came through the room.

Kael stood, on his small thin legs, in the kitchen doorway, and looked at the bowl and the cup and the parchment.

He understood, in the same way he had understood the meaning of *knowing donor* in the reliquary, what was being offered to him. It was a meal. It had been put out for him while he slept. The meat was — he extended

the small new attention of his Debt-Sight toward it, carefully, the way a man tests a new tool on a familiar wood — meat from an animal whose debt the Ledger could identify, which meant the meat had been honestly come by, which meant Sera had bought it or had been given it by a person who had honestly come by it. The cup of water glowed in the soft amber he had seen in the water-skin. The parchment did not glow at all, which meant it had been written on with an ink that had no debt attached to it, which meant the message on it would say only what the words on it said.

He walked to the table.

He climbed, on small unsteady claws, up the leg of the chair, and onto the seat, and onto the table. He stood beside the bowl. He took, in his small clawed hand, the corner of the parchment. He lifted it from under the cup.

He unfolded it.

The script was Sera's. He recognized the hand from the note in the reliquary niche. It was a small even hand,

more careful than the marginal annotations in the cult's book; she had been, on the parchment, deliberate.

Kael Veyne,

The meat is goat. It was bought at the third bridge market by a friend of mine four days ago. It has been kept in salt. The meat will agree with the body you are wearing; I have seen Imps of the Eighth Ash before, in better-controlled circumstances, and I know what they can hold. Eat slowly.

The water is from my own cistern. It is rain.

I have gone out. I will be back by the second bell of morning, which is to say in about an hour from when you read this. Do not, in the meantime, open the front door. There is a small bell on the inside of the door that will ring if it is opened; the bell is also tied to me, and I will know if it rings. The back door is bolted. The window above the stove does not open. The roof has a hatch that I have warded against opening from the inside. You are safe inside this house for one hour.

Aren Mosk is asleep in the back room and will probably remain asleep until the third bell. If he wakes, do not, please, eat him. (I am, in this sentence, partly making a small joke. I am also, in this sentence, partly not.)

If something happens that I have not anticipated, the second jar on the shelf is for you. Open it. Drink the contents. It will not heal you. It will, however, buy you forty seconds in which to do something the Ledger will not approve of, and forty seconds is sometimes enough.

Welcome, very provisionally, to my house.

— S.

He read the note.

He read the note a second time.

He read in particular the sentence about Aren Mosk, and he understood, with a small unfussy pleasure that he set down beside the previous pleasures, that Sera llyne Vasquaire was a woman who made jokes the way

Sera Ilyne Vasquaire said most other things: by laying them across the surface of a sentence so that the listener could, at his discretion, accept them as joke or as fact. She had given him a choice. The choice was: be in this house with a person who can joke about eating the cultist, or do not. He had, by reading the note, accepted the joke. He had, by accepting the joke, accepted the terms.

He folded the parchment. He set it down beside the bowl.

He ate.

He ate slowly, as the note had asked. He had not, in the body, eaten before; the body did not know what to do with food in the first six bites and then, in the seventh bite, suddenly knew. The small wrong teeth tore the goat as small wrong teeth were meant to tear goat — efficiently, with the small precise pressure of a creature whose mandible had been built for the work — and the meat went down into the small wrong stomach

and was, in there, met by something he could feel happening to it that was not digestion as he had understood digestion in his old body.

It was an accounting. The body was reading the meat. The body was identifying, in the meat, what the meat was worth — the calories, yes, but also the older measure, the one his old body had not been able to read: the debt of the goat. The goat had eaten grass. The grass had borrowed heat from the sun. The sun had been, by some long old reckoning, a creditor of the small lichen on the old stone of the hillside, which was a debtor against the patience of the stone. The chain went back. The chain went back, the body understood, for a great many years. The body took the chain into itself and converted it, with no further consultation, into the small steady increase of his Hunger by half a unit.

Hunger: 0 -> 0.5 (recovering from maintenance, ward 2, on Aren Mosk's blood).

Hunger: 0.5 -> 1 (meal: goat, salted, four-day debt-chain, clean).

available actions: minor faculty use
returns at Hunger 2.

He sat at the table after the meat was gone. He drank the water. The water tasted, on the small new palate, like the cleanness of the cistern under Sera's house, and beyond the cistern, faintly, like the rain that had filled it, and beyond the rain, very faintly, like the sea that had given up the rain in the first place. He set the cup down.

He thought, for a moment, of his mother.

He had not thought of his mother since he had died. He did not, sitting at Sera Ilyne Vasquaire's wooden table with the second bell of morning approaching from the lower city, know why he thought of her now. He thought she would have liked the cleanness of the kitchen. She had liked, in his old life, clean kitchens. She had stood very straight at the sink of her own clean kitchen for

forty years, washing plates that did not need to be washed, watching the small narrow strip of sky outside her window in the long quiet of the afternoons.

He filed the thought, very gently, and did not look at it directly.

He climbed down from the table.

He stood for a moment in the doorway of the kitchen. He listened. The clock with the six-beat cadence was, somewhere in the house, still ticking. The breathing of Aren Mosk in the back room had shifted to the deeper register of a man dreaming heavily; he was muttering, very quietly, words Kael could not quite catch and was not sure he wanted to. The house was warm. The first slow rays of the morning's light were coming through the high east window of the kitchen at an angle Kael had not seen sunlight take in many months — the angle of an autumn morning, when the sun comes in low and warm and lies across a counter the way a cat lies across a counter, deliberate, in the only patch of

warmth available.

The autumns of his old world had also done this.

He walked back into the kitchen. He stood for one moment in the sunlight. He let it lie across the back of his small purple shoulder. He thought, very precisely: *this is the first sunlight I have ever stood in on this side of dying. I am noting that. I am also noting that I have decided to note it, which suggests that the system underneath my thinking has already, on its own, classified the noticing of small physical pleasures as a thing I am now willing to do.*

He filed *that*, too.

Then, somewhere in the house, the small bell on the inside of the front door rang once.

It was not, he understood immediately, the rhythm of a person entering. A person entering would have rung the bell once on the opening of the door and once again on the closing. A person entering would,

additionally, have been Sera, and Sera had said in the note that she would be back by the second bell, and the second bell was not yet ringing in the city. The bell on the front door had rung once, by itself, the small thin ring of a thing struck against the door from the outside.

He went very still.

He listened.

He heard, through the door, the small careful breathing of a person standing on the front step. He heard, after a pause, a single light knock — *tap*, the back of a knuckle against painted wood, polite, the knock of a person who did not wish to be heard by the rest of the street.

He heard the voice.

"Sera. It's me. Don't open it. Just listen."

The voice was a woman's voice. It was not Sera's voice. It was a voice Kael had not heard, would not have recognized, and yet — by the second word — knew. He knew it the way the body had known the

meat. There was a thing in the voice that registered, on his small new instruments, as familiar in a way that bypassed his thinking.

The voice was — he understood, with a small precise click — *another candidate*.

His small new attention, without his asking, pulled toward the door. The Ledger, behind his eye, opened.

CONTACT: Candidate at front door.

identity: unknown to you.

identity, Ledger-side:

CANDIDATE THREE

("The Child Who Eats Memories")

Half-Form, juvenile.

current debts visible: many.

too many to enumerate in the
present window.

form: she is not, presently, a child.
she is presently a woman of perhaps
forty, with the borrowed face of a
midwife she ate the memory of six
years ago. she is using the face
because she is on a street and the
street expects faces.

threat: low-immediate, high-eventual.
she has not yet decided whether you
are an asset, an obstacle, or a meal.
she has come to find out.

she does not know you can hear her.

Kael read the lines.

He read the line about *she has not yet decided whether you are an asset, an obstacle, or a meal* twice, and then he made himself stop reading the Ledger and

listen.

The voice was speaking, low and quick, through the door.

"Sera. I know you can hear me, even if you don't open. I felt the room go quiet last night. The Reliquary of the Third. Whatever you did there, I felt it from the harbor. I want you to understand that I felt it and I did not run to the Brother with it. I am, in this conversation, treating you as someone I might still negotiate with. The Brother is going to come to this Quarter today. I think you have until the third bell. I think you should not be here when he gets here. I am willing to take what you have, *whatever* you have, out of the city by the cliff stair. I am willing to do it because I do not, at this moment, want what's left in the catacombs to be the Brother's. If you want a different deal, you have until the third bell to come find me. I am at the inn under the broken gull. I will be there in the back, in the small room. I am wearing the midwife. *Please, Sera. I know what you are now. I know who you have been.*"

A pause.

"Don't open the door. The man at the foot of the Lift watched me come up. He is not, at this moment, certain about either of us. Let him stay uncertain. If you have a way to leave by the back, use it. If you do not, find me."

A second pause, shorter, and then — quieter, almost conversational, the tone of a thing said only because the speaker had not been able to keep it inside her — "I miss you. I am sorry about Eshvar. It was not what I thought it was. I should have listened."

Then the small thin sound of feet stepping back from the door, very quietly, and walking, with the unhurried even pace of a midwife with no particular business, away down the street.

Kael stood in the kitchen.

He did not move for a long careful interval. He let the small breathing of Aren Mosk in the back room and the

small ticking of the six-beat clock in the parlor settle around him into the only sounds in the house, and then he allowed himself, finally, to do the thing he had not done since he had opened his eyes in the salt-circle: he sat down on the floor of a strange room and felt the full weight of the situation rather than its constituent parts.

He sat on the warm sun-strip of the kitchen floor.

He thought: I have, in fewer than fifteen hours on this side of dying, been read by three different intelligences. The Ledger has read me. Sera llyne Vasquaire has read me. Candidate Three has now read both of us — has read Sera's history, has read what was done in the Reliquary last night, has read the precise shape of the harbor of Tannev-on-the-Shoal well enough to feel a debt-suspension fail from a mile and a half away. I am, in the new market of this world, not the only person doing accounting. The other accountants have been doing it longer.

He thought: Sera knows this woman. Sera and this woman have a shared history. There is a name — Eshvar — that is shared between them and that has cost one of them, in some unspecified way, the trust of the other. The woman on the doorstep regrets it. The woman is also a Candidate, which means she is a contestant for the throne Kael is contesting for, which means the woman is — by the basic structure of the situation — a person who must, eventually, be removed from the board. The woman is offering, at this moment, an alliance. The woman is also offering it from a position in which she has, in the last sentence she spoke, audibly leaked something she did not mean to leak. *I miss you* was not a tactical line. *I miss you* was a line that escaped.

He thought: that is informative. A Candidate who can be made to leak is a Candidate who is, in some specific way, vulnerable. A Candidate who comes to the doorstep alone, knowing that the man at the foot of the Lift is watching, is a Candidate who has decided that

the cost of the visit is worth the cost of being seen. A Candidate who claims to be willing to defy the Brother is either telling the truth or building a trap. There is no way, in the present window, to know which.

He thought, lastly: she said she would take *whatever you have* out of the city. She did not say *the Eighth*. She does not, yet, know who is in this house. She felt the Reliquary fail and assumed it was Sera. The Ledger believes the woman has not yet decided whether the thing inside the Reliquary was an asset, an obstacle, or a meal. The woman is, in this moment, almost certainly assuming that Sera took something out of the Reliquary on her own, by herself. The woman has not yet imagined a small purple animal in the front hall.

He thought: I am, for as long as this assumption holds, *information*.

He thought: and Sera is not here.

He stood up.

He walked to the parlor, very quietly, to look at the clock. The clock was a small wooden thing on a shelf above a cold hearth, and it read, by the dial's twelve-point clean arrangement, that the time was perhaps fifteen minutes before the second bell. Sera had said she would be back at the second bell. Sera would, by her own clock, be at the door within fifteen minutes.

He walked back to the kitchen. He looked at the second jar on the shelf.

It was a small clear-glass jar of perhaps a thumb's height, sealed with a wax stopper, full of a liquid that was — when he turned his Debt-Sight on it — the color of a sunset he had seen once, from the windows of his old apartment, the precise dusty orange of a late summer Tokyo evening above the smog. The liquid was, the Ledger told him in the brief private way the Ledger had begun to tell him things, *bad-debt water*: the residue of an obligation that had been violently abrogated, distilled, and bottled. It would, the Ledger

said, do exactly what Sera had said it would do — buy forty seconds of disregarded accounting. The cost of using it was hers, not his; she had laid down the cost at the time she had bottled the water. The cost had, the Ledger said, *been steep*.

Kael did not, yet, take the jar down.

He went back to the front hall. He sat down on the wood floor in the spot where he had slept. He folded his small thin legs. He listened.

He was, he understood, in the position of a man who had been given a window of one hour to make a decision he did not have enough information to make. He could, in this window, do three things: he could try to leave the house and intercept Sera on the street, which would expose him to the man at the foot of the Lift and possibly to Candidate Three; he could wake Aren Mosk and assess; he could wait. The first option was the most active. The second was the most informational. The third was the most conservative.

The Sera of last night — the Sera who had walked the cellar in twenty-seven of forty-one seconds — would, he believed, want him to wait.

He waited.

He did not, in the waiting, do nothing. He thought about Aren Mosk. He thought about the body of the cultist in the back room of Sera's house — the body that was, by the Ledger's accounting, an asset of his own as much as a guest of Sera's. He thought about the cultist's wounded hand. He thought about what the cultist would do, when he woke, in a Sera-less house, with a Candidate-Three-shaped threat known to be wandering the morning streets of the Quarter and a Brother-shaped threat known to be on his way. Aren Mosk was, in any honest reckoning, a witness against Kael of considerable value to either of those two threats. Aren Mosk had, last night, become a witness *for* Kael — a knowing donor, a binder of one maintenance-debt against the Eighth — but that loyalty was, in the present morning, fourteen hours old and

untested.

He thought: Aren Mosk is a vulnerability that walks.

He thought: I have not yet decided what to do about it.

He thought: I will decide when Sera is back.

It was, in this judgment, the same judgment he had made at the table about the Stage 2 advancement: not yet. He had decided, in the small hours of the night, that the advancement was a transaction he wished to defer until he understood its full cost. He was deciding, now, that Aren Mosk's status as a non-vulnerability was a determination he wished to defer until he had Sera's read on it. He was, he registered with a small clean cold pleasure, becoming a creature who deferred.

His old life had not been a life of deferral. His old life had been a life of fast calculation and quick commitment, the analyst's pleasure of closing the model and clicking *send*. He had built a career on that. He had also, on this side of dying, met three things in

fourteen hours that had taught him, in small specific ways, that the move he had spent thirty-one years perfecting was the wrong move for this game.

He was learning to wait.

He was, he thought with the small private amusement of a man recognizing a habit forming, becoming an accountant who let the books close on their own.

The clock in the parlor struck the second bell.

It rang once. It was a different note than the bell of the city — closer, smaller, brighter — and it rang once because it was, evidently, set to ring half-hour. It had not yet finished ringing when the bell on the inside of the front door rang twice, in the rhythm of an arrival.

Kael stood up.

The door opened.

Sera came in. She did not, immediately, close it behind her. She stood, in the doorway, with one hand still on

the brass knob and the other holding a small loaf of bread, and her cold-water eyes went, in one quick precise pass, from Kael on the floor in the hall to the kitchen at the end of the hall to the empty bowl on the table to Kael again, and she said — in a voice that was perfectly level and entirely without surprise —

"You ate."

"Yes."

"Good."

She closed the door. She set the small bell against its rest with a finger to keep it from ringing a second time as the door swung. She slid the bolt. She turned to face him.

She was, in the morning light through the curtain, thinner than she had been in the dark of the corridor. He had not been able to see her properly last night. He saw now that her hair, the rope of silver braid, had a fine pale wisp at the brow that suggested she had been

older than he had thought — she was perhaps thirty, perhaps thirty-two, not the twenty-eight he had estimated in the chapel — and that her face had, around the eyes, the small fine lines of a woman who read in low light. Her hands were ungloved. He could see, on the back of her right hand, a faint blue tracery that had not, last night, been visible to him.

He understood the tracery without asking. She was a Tallymark. The mark was small, neat, professional. She had, somewhere in her life, taken whatever training the Academy at Thal-Veren gave its students, and she had taken it well enough to be marked.

He filed the data.

He said, "There was a knock."

Sera went very still. The bread in her hand did not, for a moment, move.

"When."

"Eight minutes ago, by your parlor clock."

"Tell me."

He told her.

He told her everything, in the precise order in which it had happened — the single ring of the bell, the careful breathing on the step, the knock, the voice. He told her the words the voice had said, as nearly as he could remember them, which was very nearly. He told her about the leaked sentence at the end and his read of it. He told her about the Ledger's identification: *Candidate Three. The Child Who Eats Memories. Half-Form, juvenile*. He told her that the woman had been wearing, the Ledger had said, the borrowed face of a midwife. He told her about the inn under the broken gull and the offer of the cliff stair.

He did not tell her, immediately, the last thing.

He waited, because he was learning to wait, until he had told her the rest.

Then he said, "She said your name, Sera. She said: *I miss you. I am sorry about Eshvar. It was not what I thought it was. I should have listened.*"

He watched her face.

He had not been planning to watch her face. He had been planning to deliver the line evenly, without freight, and let her response speak. He found, in the moment of saying it, that he had — somewhere in the small new instinct of the small new body — decided that the line was important enough to deliver with his small new eyes on hers, because the line was not about him. The line was about Sera, and Sera deserved, from him, the small courtesy of being looked at when the line landed.

It landed.

He watched Sera Ilyne Vasquaire's face do, in the slow seconds after the word *Eshvar*, what her face had not done at any point last night: it broke.

It did not break entirely. It did not break in the way Aren Mosk's face had broken in the chapel; Sera was not, in any sense Kael had so far observed, a person who broke entirely. The cold-water eyes filled, slightly, with a wet sheen they had not had a moment before, and the small fine line at the corner of her mouth pulled down in a specific shape Kael, in his old life, would have called *grief-recognized-too-late*, and her hand on the loaf of bread tightened until the bread cracked along its top crust with a small dry sound that he heard very clearly in the silent hall.

She did not, however, drop the bread.

She did not sit down.

She closed her eyes for one long even breath, and she opened them, and she said —

"Then she's still alive. After all."

Kael said nothing.

He understood, with a small private courtesy he had not, in his old life, often extended, that he was not to ask.

He had been told, last night on the step, *you are not, ever, to ask me how I came to know what I know about your kind. I will tell you when I am ready to tell you.* He had agreed. The Eshvar question was a question of the same shape. He set it down beside the other questions he had not asked. He held very still.

Sera opened her eyes the rest of the way.

She walked, on legs that were not quite as steady as they had been a moment ago but were nonetheless walking, into the kitchen. She set the bread on the table. She stood for a small even span of seconds with her hand flat on the wood beside it. Then she turned, and she said, in the level voice that had returned to her:

"All right. We have, by my best estimate, until the third bell to leave. That is two hours. Two hours is enough. I had been planning to take you out of the city through

the harbor in three days. The plan was not, frankly, a great plan; I had been hoping for a slower opening of the game than the game has chosen to give us. We will now do the worse version of it. We will leave today. We will leave by a route that the Brother does not know I have, because the route is one I have not used, and because the route requires the small house at the end of this street to do me a favor I have been keeping in reserve."

She looked at Kael.

"I am going to ask you to do something I would not ask, if I had three more days. I am going to ask you to be carried out of the city in a basket, dressed as a thing I cannot, in this kitchen, name aloud, by a person whose loyalty is to me but whose loyalty I have so far never tested. The basket will be heavy. The person carrying it will know there is something living in it. The person carrying it will not, however, know what. The person will be told a story I have, this morning while you slept, half-written. The story is mostly true. The pieces of it

that are not true are pieces I have selected for reasons I will explain on the road. I would not, if I had three more days, lie to this person. I am, today, going to lie a little. I will tell you the lies before I tell them so that you are not surprised when you hear them."

She paused.

"The other thing I am going to ask is that, when we leave this kitchen, you let me handle Aren Mosk."

Kael said, "How."

"There is a — a thing I can do, with the Tallymark on my hand and a small ritual that takes perhaps four minutes, that will lay a sleep on him for the next twelve hours. The sleep will not harm him. The sleep is, in fact, a kindness. He has not yet absorbed what happened to him in the catacombs. If he is awake on the road today he will not be useful. If he is asleep, he will be a thing we can deliver, with the basket, into the hands of the small house at the end of this street, which has, among its other functions, a back room where people who

cannot be on the streets of Tannev are kept for a few days at low cost. He will wake in three days. The Brother will not, by then, know where he is. He will be safe. Possibly safer than us."

Kael considered this.

He considered, in particular, the line *the Tallymark on my hand and a small ritual that takes perhaps four minutes.*

He considered the line *the sleep is, in fact, a kindness.*

He considered the fact that Sera was, in this proposal, going to do a ritual that involved the Tallymark on her hand — a public mark, a thing of the Academy at Thal-Veren — in a kitchen where the front door had, eight minutes ago, been knocked at by a Candidate who could, by the Ledger's own account, *feel the room go quiet from the harbor* when a debt-suspension failed. He considered the possibility that any ritual Sera performed in this kitchen in the next four minutes would be felt, by Candidate Three, almost immediately. He

considered that Sera had certainly thought of this. He considered that Sera was nonetheless willing to do the ritual.

He thought: she is making a trade. She is trading the secrecy of her location for the immobilization of Aren Mosk. She has, presumably, calculated that the trade is worth it.

He thought: she is, in this trade, accepting that we will leave before Candidate Three can arrive. She is, in this trade, accepting that the third bell is the right deadline. She is, in this trade, accepting that Aren Mosk's safety is worth being detected.

He thought: I would not, in the same position, have made the same trade.

He thought, more slowly: I am not yet sure I would not have been wrong.

He said, "Do the ritual."

Sera looked at him for a small even second. There was, in the look, the smallest possible note of surprise — as though she had been bracing for an argument and was finding, in the absence of one, an unexpected room. She nodded. She walked out of the kitchen, toward the back room where Aren Mosk slept.

Kael, on the warm wood of the kitchen floor, did not follow her.

He sat down again.

He looked, for one more small moment, at the sun-strip on the floor. The strip had moved, in the small span of his standing, perhaps four inches to the east; the morning was advancing. The first slow notes of the second bell of the city had, by now, finished ringing somewhere over the rooftops, and the lanterns of the Quarter — he could see one of them through the high east window — had begun, very faintly, to dim, the way the lanterns of the Quarter dimmed when the daylight rose.

He looked down at his small clawed hand.

He looked at the VIII.

He thought, with the cold small honesty he was trying, on this side of dying, to keep practicing: *I do not know if I trust Sera Ilyne Vasquaire. I know that she has earned, in the last fifteen hours, more trust from me than any person earned in my last fifteen years. I know that the earning was real. I know that the earning was also, on her part, a transaction I have not yet been told the price of.*

He thought: *I have decided to pay the price anyway.*

He thought: *that decision is one the Ledger has not yet costed for me. I will be paying for it for a long time.*

The Ledger, behind his attention, ticked.

You have just chosen to extend trust to a person who has not yet earned, by your old metric, the trust extended.

The Ledger notes this as the second action you have taken on this side of dying that you would not have taken on the other.

The first was asking instead of taking.
This is the second.

A pattern is, technically, two points.

The Ledger files them together.

He read the line.

He did not, this time, file it.

He left it open, in his attention, where he could see it.

In the back room of Sera Ilyne Vasquaire's house, the soft low voice of a woman beginning a small careful ritual had begun, and Kael Veyne, Candidate the Eighth, eighteen inches tall, with a meal of cold goat in his belly and the first sunlight of a new world on his small purple shoulder, listened to the cadence of the words she said, and waited, and did not — for the first

morning of his second life — wish to be anywhere else.

Outside, in the quiet street under the dimming blue lanterns of the Lantern Quarter of Tannev-on-the-Shoal, a midwife with a borrowed face walked back down Cobbler's Lift toward the harbor, holding the small private dignity of a woman who had told a thing she had not meant to tell, and a man in a dark coat that did not match the cut of the city stood at the foot of the Lift with his hands in his pockets and watched her go, and decided — finally, after a night of uncertainty — that he would, after all, send word.

The word would, by the third bell of the morning, be on the desk of the Brother.

The Brother would read it with the small steady attention with which the Brother read everything.

He would set the parchment down. He would, with one finger, draw a line through the eighth of the eight names on the list on his desk.

The line would, when he drew it, not be a line of cancellation.

It would be a line of acknowledgment.

The Brother of the Veiled Seven would, for the first time in nine hundred and four years of a project he had been patient with, sit forward in his chair.

He would, after some thought, say a single word aloud to the empty room.

"Begin."

— *end of Chapter Six* —